Reflection on our Interview with Engr. Delacruz

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2. Introduction

As part of our exploration of the experiences and career opportunities of Computer Engineering graduates, we conducted an interview with Engr. Alexander Jake Delacruz, a Bachelor of Science in Computer Engineering alumnus from the Academic Year 2025–2026. Luckily he also graduated from the same school (Technological Institute of the Philippines) The purpose of the interview was to gain a better understanding of the academic journey, challenges, and professional experiences of someone who graduated from the same department and pursued a career in the industry. Throughout the interview, we discussed several topics. We also explored his transition from being a student to becoming a working professional, particularly his experiences in the field of Data Science, the skills he considers essential in the workplace, and the lessons he learned along the way. Through this interview, we hoped to gain valuable insights and practical advice that could help us better prepare for the challenges ahead, make informed decisions about our future careers, and understand what it takes to succeed as aspiring Computer Engineers.

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3. Summary of the Interview

During the interview, the Computer Engineering alumnus shared his personal experiences, challenges, achievements, and lessons learned throughout his college journey. He explained that he chose Computer Engineering because of his interest in computers, mathematics, and the combination of hardware and software, which made the program more appealing to him than other computer-related courses. However, his journey was not easy. Some of the difficulties he experienced included the sudden transition from online to face-to-face classes, understanding complicated electrical engineering subjects, and balancing his thesis with other academic

responsibilities and On-the-Job Training (OJT). Despite these challenges, he recalled some of his most enjoyable college experiences, particularly participating in hackathons, competing against other universities, and attending school-sponsored events. From his personal perspective, joining competitions was one of the best ways to gain practical knowledge and experience beyond what was taught in the classroom. He emphasized that winning or losing was not the most important part, but rather having the courage to participate and learn from the experience. Looking back, he also admitted that one thing he would have done differently was being more selective about the activities and projects he joined, realizing that not every opportunity was worth his time. He encouraged current Computer Engineering students to explore opportunities outside school, develop their communication and presentation skills, and continue moving forward despite experiencing failures.

After graduating, the alumnus pursued a career in Data Science, where he currently works with cloud computing, data engineering, automation, monitoring, model training, and deployment. Based on his professional experience, he explained that one of the biggest differences between college and the workplace is how knowledge is applied. While studying often emphasizes theoretical concepts, examinations, and memorization, working in the industry requires practical problem-solving and knowing how to use available information effectively. He personally believes that having excellent grades does not automatically make someone successful, especially if they struggle to apply what they have learned. He also emphasized the importance of building a portfolio while still studying, as it can help demonstrate one's abilities and experiences to future employers. When discussing the rapid development of artificial intelligence, he shared his perspective that specializing in a particular field is becoming increasingly important because technology is advancing too quickly for someone to master everything. Rather than relying entirely on AI, he believes professionals should develop enough expertise to recognize its mistakes and limitations. One of his strongest messages was that technical skills can be developed over time, but communication, critical thinking, common sense, and the ability to present ideas clearly are equally important. Overall, his experiences showed us that becoming a successful Computer Engineer is not simply about earning good grades or mastering programming languages, but also about continuously learning, gaining practical experience, making wise decisions, and being willing to improve after every failure.

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4. Personal Reflection

What struck us the most during the interview was the alumnus's perspective on how grades and technical skills are not the only things that determine success in Computer Engineering. He emphasized the importance of communication, critical thinking, and especially presentation skills. One thing that stood out to us was when he mentioned that there are people who are highly skilled in technical work but struggle to present and explain their ideas to others. It made us

realize that being good engineers is not just about knowing how to solve problems, but also being able to communicate those solutions clearly, especially to clients or audiences who may not have any technical background. We also found his advice about exploring opportunities outside the classroom meaningful because it reminded us that learning should not be limited to what is being taught in school.

After hearing his experiences, we felt more motivated to participate in activities such as hackathons, competitions, and other opportunities that could help us develop our skills. It also changed how we want to approach our studies. Instead of focusing only on getting high grades, we want to understand our subjects well enough that we can apply what we learn to our own projects and future work. We also want to start creating more personal projects and exploring programming languages such as C++, Python, and JavaScript, even if we eventually pursue different fields. Another thing that surprised us was hearing about the difficulties he experienced during college, particularly the subjects he struggled with and the times he had to stay up all night studying. As first-year Computer Engineering students, we are already experiencing difficulties keeping up with our studies, so we can relate to some of his struggles. Although we are uncertain and somewhat afraid of the challenges that are still ahead of us, we are also looking forward to facing and overcoming them. His advice about treating failures as learning experiences reminded us that struggling is part of the process and that what matters is continuing to move forward.

As for our future careers, we are still unsure which specific fields we want to pursue because we are still discovering our interests and capabilities. For now, we believe it would be best to explore different fields and eventually choose career paths based on both our strengths and the opportunities available in the industry. However, regardless of which paths we take, we want to become individuals who genuinely understand what we have learned rather than simply aiming to be among the highest-ranking students. We want to be capable of creating useful projects, confidently presenting our ideas, and applying our knowledge to real-world problems. Most importantly, we want to develop the determination to keep going even when things become difficult. One of the biggest lessons we will carry from this interview is that success does not necessarily mean never failing, but rather being willing to learn from our failures and use those experiences to become better versions of ourselves.

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5. Connection to Course or Program

The interview connects closely to what we are currently learning as Computer Engineering students, especially in subjects involving programming, mathematics, problem-solving, and understanding how hardware and software work together. As first-year students, most of what we learn focuses on building our foundational knowledge, and the alumni's experiences helped us understand how these lessons will eventually be applied in the workplace. For example, he mentioned that programming languages such as C++ and Python are commonly used in his field,

which made us appreciate the importance of learning programming concepts early on. The interview also challenged our understanding of what it means to become a successful Computer Engineer. Initially, we thought that having strong technical knowledge and achieving good grades were among the most important things to focus on. However, his experiences made us realize that being able to apply what we learn, communicate our ideas effectively, and work on real-world projects is just as important. It reinforced the idea that Computer Engineering is not simply about memorizing concepts or passing examinations, but about developing the ability to solve problems and continuously adapt to new technologies. Because of this, We want to approach my subjects with a greater focus on understanding their practical applications rather than studying only to achieve good grades.

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6. Conclusion

Overall, the interview was a meaningful and valuable experience that gave us a better understanding of the challenges, responsibilities, and opportunities that come with pursuing Computer Engineering. Hearing the alumnus share his experiences taught us several important lessons, particularly that having high grades does not necessarily mean being able to apply what we have learned in real-world situations. We also learned the importance of developing communication and presentation skills, especially when explaining technical ideas to clients or people who may not have prior knowledge of the subject. Another lesson that stood out to us was his advice to participate in hackathons and explore opportunities outside the classroom, because whether we win or lose, the experience itself allows us to learn and improve. His perspective on the growing influence of artificial intelligence also made us realize the value of developing expertise in a particular field rather than relying entirely on technology to solve problems. As a first-year Computer Engineering student, we know that there will be more challenges ahead, especially after hearing about his difficulties with certain subjects, thesis requirements, and balancing OJT with academic responsibilities. Although we are still uncertain about our future career path, we want to start building personal projects, strengthen my programming knowledge, and focus on understanding my lessons rather than simply memorizing them for examinations. We are grateful to the alumnus for taking the time to share his experiences and advice with us. Most importantly, We will carry his reminder that failure should not discourage us from trying again, because what matters is learning from those experiences and continuing to move forward.

7. Appendices

